cannons, uncountable treasures, and plentiful stocks of gun-powder.'[16] These figures were probably optimistic. But for all his problems, the Shah's prospects were now brighter than they had been for months.[17]

On 7 February, Shuja wrote in his own hand a heartfelt message to 'my beloved son' Prince Timur who was with General Nott in Kandahar. Mohan Lal Kashmiri, who had remained in Kabul and so escaped the massacre, promised to get the letter through to the British garrison there using his network of spies and runners. Shuja opened by writing of his acceptance of the incomprehensible workings of divine will represented by fate, and of the shame and sadness he felt at what had taken place. 'Here we have had a repetition of those scenes which the people of this place have so often enacted,' he wrote. 'I frequently warned the English of what was coming – but they paid no regard to me. Fate has decreed that those scenes which I had hoped never to see again should take place. The people of Kabul sounded a war cry against Unbelievers and even withdrew themselves from me, saying, the Shah is with the English.' He then explained to his son that he had been forced to dissimulate in order to survive: 'I told them: "What can the English be to me? They certainly treated me with kindness, and I was a long time a guest of the nation – but what else?" This even was unworthy of me – may God shield me from the shame I feel [for disowning my friends]. If, by the blessing of God, I should ever see you again, I will unfold to you the secrets of my heart. It was my fate to act as I have done.'

He then went on to tell Prince Timur of his hopes. 'Do not grieve,' he wrote, 'a better state of things is now in progress. Be happy and contented – we shall still attain the objects of which we have been disappointed and I shall keep a careful eye upon you. I cannot send you the particulars as I could wish, for the road is full of danger. There is much to communicate – if matters should turn out happily, and according to my heart's desire, you will know all very soon!'[18]

By now, with the rebel Afghan leadership still fractured and disunited, Shuja's letters were showing his increasing confidence. To MacGregor in Jalalabad he wrote urging a rapid British advance on Kabul – 'Not a cat belonging to you shall be injured,' he promised – before returning to his old theme of the faithlessness of the Barakzais. He particularly decried the respect that he imagined the British were still paying to his old enemy, Amir Dost Mohammad. 'I cannot think that you are possessed of a proper sense of honor,' he lectured MacGregor.